

Signing the Lease

Remember four little words: read the small print. You need to protect yourself by knowing all the rules and regulations of living in your new space and of leaving it. If there are provisions in the lease that you object to, see if you can work out a compromise with the landlord. Cross out the unwanted language for any changes the two of you agree to, initial and date the change, and have the landlord do the same. Don't rely on oral agreements. They're difficult, if not impossible, to prove.

If there's something you don't understand, ask the landlord or property manager to explain it. Don't make any assumptions. A few things you might want to ask up front are:

- Is there an on-site manager?
- What kind of routine maintenance is performed and what am I personally responsible for?
- How much notice do I need to give when leaving?
- How is trash handled?
- What utilities and other services are included in the rent?
- Are there provisions in the lease that allow the rent to be raised during the lease term?

Don't be embarrassed if you have a lot of questions. Landlords expect questions, and once you sign the lease, it's too late. Make sure that the answers you get from your landlord correspond with the lease document.



Most landlords check your credit report and rental history, and charge you a fee of \$10 to \$35. Most will also verify your income to ensure that it's at least three times your monthly rent, so if rent is \$800 a month, your monthly income would have to be at least \$2,400.